

I Didn't Realize It Was Abuse—Until



JESSICA KNIGHT

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You don't wake up one morning and suddenly realize you're in an emotional relationship. That's not how it works. It's a slow unraveling. A quiet drip of confusion that dulls your instincts until you no longer trust

Every time I got close to the truth of what was going on, I was pulled back. I rationalized. I minimized. I clung to hope because it was the only thing that felt familiar.

Emotional abuse rarely begins with cruelty. It begins with intensity and a deep connection. The kind that makes you believe you've finally found someone who understands you in a way no one else ever has. By the time you realize you're drowning in the water so long that you no longer remember what it felt like to breathe.

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Behind every bad bitch is a sweet girl who got tired of everyone's bullshit

The Manipulation I Didn't See—Until I Did

My ex-fiancé was a master at shifting the goalposts. What was acceptable became offensive the next. When I handled things with the care he was similar to the care I give my daughter..not adults), I was still wrong. No matter how hard I tried, it was never enough.

When he needed help managing his budget, I did it. When I tried to

ignored them or told me I was irrational. When I expressed how I felt, he twisted my words and made me the villain for even speaking up because I was ‘too emotional’ on him.”

I allowed it to happen because I thought I was being understanding and supporting someone who was struggling. He had a lot going on. I thought my love meant patience, flexibility, and grace - but that also meant manipulation and abuse.

At the time, I didn’t have the language for what was happening. I often felt like I was always left those conversations feeling like I was the problem.

Now I understand that I was experiencing DARVO—Deny, Attack, and Victimize. Each time I brought up something that hurt me, he twisted it and made me the offender. He was more upset that I would even say something. If I voiced a need, he accused me of being selfish. If I tried to set a boundary, I was labeled controlling.

Every interaction became a trap. Every attempt at honesty was used

The Gaslighting Was Relentless

He rewrote history so often that I began to doubt my own memory. I had been “mean all week” when I had been carefully walking on eggshe focused on my tone. He accused me of pushing him away when all I wanted was for time to think.

Each argument ended the same way: with me apologizing for some

and wondering if I was the one destroying the relationship.

What I didn't yet realize was that I was no longer just emotionally connected, I was physiologically trapped. My nervous system was in a constant state of freeze, or fawn. I was trying to survive something my body knew was wrong, but my mind hadn't caught up.

The Emotional Rollercoaster of Trauma Bonding

I knew the relationship was unhealthy. I felt it in my chest, in my bones. My sense of self and my world kept shrinking. I didn't laugh as much. I didn't rest. I didn't feel safe anymore. **Still, every time I tried to pull away, he reeled me back in, making it feel impossible, like the entire world would collapse if I left.** I would never leave for space.

He wasn't always cruel. Sometimes, he was the man I fell in love with. He said the right things. He wrote them down. He painted a future for me. He reminded me of the version of him I had been holding onto for so long.

And that is the trap of trauma bonding. It is addictive. It hijacks your nervous system and wires you to chase the very person who is hurting you. You don't even realize you're confusing relief for love. **You interpret the absence of harm as connection.**

Every tender moment, every apology, every "I love you, I need you" made the times he withheld affection, punished me with silence, or turned his back on me feel like a betrayal.

against me.

Those were not glimpses of the real man. They were part of the cycle of control.

What made it hardest to leave wasn't the pain, it was the hope. I hoped I could just do one more thing right, maybe it would go back to the beginning, all of the therapy he was doing for trauma would help. Maybe I could convert the version of him that never actually existed. But I didn't need to "earn" my place by doing anything wrong....other than abandoning myself.

The Moments I Knew—And Still Struggled

I remember being sick—feverish, depleted—and he barely noticed. I was consumed with his own stress and his own story that my suffering was a distraction. In that moment, I realized how little space I occupied in his emotional world. He had to break through his feelings, emotions, theories, judgements, and even acknowledge that I existed.

At one point, when I realized he was relentlessly selfish, I tried setting boundaries around texting. He blew past it immediately. It wasn't a mistake. It was watching to see if he still had access to me, and I watched myself realize how full well what he was doing, but still hoping he might finally understand.

He often walked into my space without asking. He took what he wanted without warning. I knew it was an intimidation tactic, even if I didn't want to admit it at the time. He was making it clear that my space was only mine if he allowed it.

Instead of supporting me as a parent, he made it about his own hurt. In that moment something shifted within me. He wasn't just neglecting me; he was sabotaging my ability to exist outside of him.

Even with all of this, I stayed longer than I want to admit. Shame convinced me I failed. Shame told me I should have seen it sooner. But shame was just a tool. Abusers rely on it. They know that if we carry enough guilt, we'll keep staying. We'll stay.

The Hard Truth: He Knew What He Was Doing

For so long, I tried to make sense of his behavior. I wanted to understand it. I wanted him to work on his own trauma.

Eventually, I had to accept the truth: he wasn't confused. He wasn't broken. He was deliberate.

He had been told his behavior was abusive by me *and* the couples therapist. He had been in therapy. He had been given tools. He had been offered clarity. He chose to harm me because he could not get out of his own way.

He didn't lack the capacity to change. He lacked the desire to let go of what was more important to him than loving me in a healthy way.

How I Finally Broke Free

Recognizing the abuse was one thing. Acting on it was another.

I started documenting everything—each boundary violation, every conversation, every pattern I had normalized. I stopped trying to win, I stopped trying to explain the harm back to the person causing it.

I stopped believing he would change. This was the hardest part but I told myself every day that ***he would not change.***

When I finally left, he did exactly what I expected. He begged. He performed remorse. And when that didn't work, he escalated—because abusers do when they lose control.

But I did not go back.

If You're in This Situation

If any part of this feels familiar, I want you to know something.

You are not crazy. You are not too sensitive. You are not imagining the problem.

You are waking up to the truth, and once you see it clearly, you cannot go back.

You do not need more proof. You do not need his permission to walk away. You do not need to wait for something to break in order to leave.

You already know - and knowing is enough.

You do not need to collapse in order to justify your decision. Quitting is enough. You do not need to set everything on fire to escape. You choose yourself.

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If this feels like your story—or something close to it—you are not alone. What is in your chest is not confusion. It is your truth. It is your body trying to tell you something.

I work with women who are navigating trauma bonds, high-conflict relationships, and the emotional wreckage left behind by coercive and narcissistic abuse.

If you are ready to reclaim your voice, rebuild your identity, and create a life you love, I can help.

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You are not alone. You are not too much.

You are waking up—and that changes everything.

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"The potential you see in other people isn't real. It is the projection of what y
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